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Wayne Bergeron

Wayne Bergeron has been a first-call trumpet player in L.A. studios and beyond for many decades. His distinctive lead trumpet skills can be heard on over 400 films and television shows, and he has recorded as a leader as well.

Wayne was interviewed via Zoom on December 29, 2020 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College and I'm very pleased to have Wayne Bergeron with me today. And if you don't mind, could we see the bottom of your shirt? Yeah okay, we can see it, I love you this much … as long as we're six feet apart.

WB: Exactly. So that lets us know this is being done during the pandemic, obviously.

MR: That's right. If it wasn't I'd be shaking hands with you in some other site.

WB: I wish we were in person of course, but unfortunately this is the way we've got to do things for the time being.

MR: That's right. We're going to talk about that a little later. I wanted to give you a musical test —

WB: Uh oh.

MR: In the form of a trivia question, and you'll probably see where this is going in a hurry. What do these media events or people have in common: "The Incredibles," Rosemary Clooney, "Family Guy," Gordon Goodwin's Big Phat Band, and Green Day?

WB: Huge egos. Those might be projects that I've worked on over the years.

MR: That's right and you know I could do that for the next hour, just read them. So speaking of huge egos, do you find it necessary to have an ego in your business or is it better not to have one?

WB: Well I mean if you're a drummer, a trumpet player, or a rock guitarist, there's a certain amount of confidence — you know when you're playing by yourself, you're playing a solo, there's a certain amount of confidence we all need and I don't think it should cross the line into ego but you need to have enough confidence in your own abilities I think. As the great George Graham, who was a great lead trumpet player, once told me there's a fine line between getting discovered and found out. And so I think it's the same thing between confidence and ego.

MR: Can you explain that? Being discovered and found out?

WB: Well for instance, I've always been of the school that if you play music you don't really need to say anything. We don't even need to be speaking the same language. You could be speaking French and I could be speaking Spanish. But if we picked up our instruments

and just played we know everything we need to know about each other's ability. Right? So there's a lot of musicians, and this is where the ego comes in, where they have to talk a big game. Because maybe there's some insecurities in their own playing that they want to hide. And so that's the ego part of it. And so George used to say that, you know people talk about how good they are, and then when you hear them play finally well you just got found out. Instead of getting discovered — and you can get discovered by just, and I tell students this all the time, they want to know, "Oh how do I get work?" And I go, "Well you're asking the wrong question." I go, "You need to hone your craft." And I go, "And when you play really well," I go, "good news travels fast." I said, "And if you don't play really well, I said, "that news still travels really fast." So it kind of takes care of itself, you know, the whole ego thing. Because all you need to know is to listen to somebody play, you know what they're all about. So it's best that you keep your mouth shut and play I guess is the moral to the story. You know I've always tried to have been of that mindset.

MR: Well you already started to answer a question that this led to, and you sound like a fairly modest guy but can you tell us why you were chosen so many times over the years for the work you do?

WB: Good question. You know nobody gets thrown into this business and starts doing all the work right away. It's a slow burn usually. And somebody, maybe somebody hears you play and you get an opportunity, you know, somebody hires you. "Hey I heard this saxophone player" whatever, "at this club. I wonder if they'd be right for this recording session. Does anybody know this person?" And people ask. And you go, "Oh yeah, that's Bob Shepherd, oh yeah, of course we know Bob Shepherd, he's great." You know. And then you get that opportunity, and then you have to prove yourself in that opportunity you know, and it doesn't mean you're going to start working for those people nonstop because there's other people that have been working for them for years maybe. But as you get in there and prove yourself. And if you get a good opportunity and you do well, another opportunity will come from those people, even if it's down the road two months. And eventually you get into the mix. People retire. People pass away. People piss contractors off and they stop hiring them, and you move up those lists. And that's been my career. And I'll tell you just a quick story about this, because it's a true story. There's a contractor here named Joe Solo. And he's 95 years old now. And he came out to the West Coast from New York, he was a New York studio musician. And he was a contractor for "The Carol Burnett Show." So when that show came out here he came out with the show. He contracted the musicians on that show. And I got — the first big movie I ever did was for him, this was 35 years ago probably, this movie called "Another Stakeout" and it wasn't necessarily a big movie in the theaters. It was fairly big, Emilio

Estevez, but it was a hundred piece orchestra and I got called to do this thing. And it was on recommendations from some colleagues I'd been playing in a couple of kicks bands with. Warren Luening, a really great trumpet player from here who's passed away, and George Graham, who played lead trumpet with many big bands here. Both mentors of mine. And the contractor had gone through the list of players and there was a lot of work happening that week and they go, "Well try this guy, Wayne, you know, I play in Bob Florence's band with him, he's a solid player." So I came in and I got a call to play fourth trumpet for three days of this movie. The first day I was there I was very nervous, because I'm sitting there, it's a hundred piece orchestra and the trumpet section is three of my heroes and I've never been so terrified to play fourth trumpet in my entire life you know. And I like to say I was as nervous as a hooker in church. That's kind of my standard line. So I did the date and I got my composure and finally started feeling comfortable playing. Things were going well. And at the end of the date I gave my paperwork to this contractor to Joe so I can get paid, and all my stuff. And he said, "Everybody said you did a really nice job." And I said, "Well thank you for the opportunity you know, it was really fun." And he goes, "I'm going to put you on my list man." And I go, "Oh great." He goes, "I'm going to put you on the bottom of my list." And so I kind of laughed. He goes, "You want to know why I'm going to put you on the bottom of my list?" I go, "Yeah, why?" He goes, "Well of all these players that I've been using for forty years some of them, who should I fire to move you up? Which one of my employees should I fire?" And that always kind of stuck with me. I go well of course that makes total sense. And that was his line, he goes, "Trust me, as they retire, die or piss me off you'll move up." And I now play first trumpet for Joe Solo. So that's the — it all kind of happened that way. You know and it's slow. I moved into the ranks of his people and people moved on. So that's how I feel like my career has gone, just in general, how I got into the business. But you do have to have that preparedness meets opportunity thing. You need to be prepared so when you get that opportunity you're ready for the task at hand, and fortunately I got in there and it was easy. I didn't get thrown in on first trumpet. I got in on fourth trumpet so I could learn and grow and learn how to play in that environment and every time I would sit next to those players, because I just felt they brought a lot more to the table than I did at that time especially. I learned a lot. And I've always been kind of a listening learner, not as much of a book-smart learner. When I hear something I like I always tried to imitate it you know.

MR: It's a great story and your students would profit from knowing how do you piss a contractor off?

WB: You show up at the last minute even though you're on time. You're disruptive on the session, which musicians can be disruptive let's face it, you know, we're funny people,

especially jazz musicians. So if you're on a big orchestra date and you've got a big jazz brass section there because it's a jazz — you know we're cracking jokes, the string players are over there stiff as a board of course. And so you have to know your environment and know when you can let loose a little bit. And so there's situations that I know to keep my mouth shut and you say "yes sir, no sir" and you just play the part and you take the money and you go home. And then there's situations where you're around friends and you know the composer — I mean Gordon Goodwin's on the podium you know, for doing a movie like "The Incredibles." I mean it's intense because the music's hard, but there's laughter and we can make jokes.

MR: Right.

WB: So you have to know when to do that. But you can. Not all contractors like that. They want you to shut up, they want it pin-drop quiet, and it usually is like that because everybody's taking it very seriously of course. But that's a way you can piss a contractor — but the showing up at the last minute, which I watched some musicians get drummed out of the business kind of. Because they would show up ten minutes before downbeat, which seems like plenty of time. But I'm the first one there. When I go to one of my TV shows that I do, you know, "Family Guy" or something, I walk in, I'm the first brass player on that stage. And the contractor and the composers always come in, "Hey Wayne, how you doing?" And I'm warming up. And I'm doing that for me. I'm not doing that to impress them, it's just what I do. I get there early and I warm up. But I think they see that and in their minds, boy, you can always count on this person to be there. And so if it's ten 'til the start time and I'm not there, they know something's wrong, you know I was in an accident or something bad has happened you know.

MR: Did that translate into the number of dates you would accept in one day? I remember, I was lucky enough to have a conversation with Joe Wilder, who did a lot in New York. And he would comment, he didn't name names, but that people would accept multiple dates in a day knowing they weren't going to be able to get to the third one on time.

WB: You used to be able to get away with that at one point in this town. I mean there was a time when there was a lot of work and there was a lot of very high demand players, players that were doing everything, doing all the pop recording and just doing several sessions a day. And they'd take a 10:00 that's supposed to go to 1:00 and then there'd be a 1:30 date across town and they would take it in hopes that they were going to get out early. And sometimes they were. And many times they'd go, "Oh we're always done early with these guys" you know, because it's a regular TV show. "Well we're always done early, with "CHiPs" or whatever shows they might be doing. But then they would get there late but they were in such high demand that they would get there and they would get the job done so well that they would still get done early, even on the job they

started late on. So a lot of these players, like people just expected them to be late. That does not exist anymore. And it's a little bit greedy you know. I won't say I've never been guilty of like threading the needle. Because when they call you for a recording session, a three hour session is standard. Like 10:00 to 1:00 is standard, right? So if you're going to do a double session it would be 10:00 to 1:00 with an hour lunch break, and then 2:00 to 5:00. So let's say you were doing just the 10:00 to 1:00 that morning, and somebody called you for a 2:00. Right? You go, "Okay, an hour, I got that" but to go from Capitol to here, that's okay, traffic's not bad this time, I can make it and be there fifteen minutes early, no problem, with no traffic, without any problems. But when you take a three hour call the union contract is they can keep you an extra hour overtime. They can't keep you another one after that, but they can. Legally you're held to four hours. So that's, you know, I've done this a couple of times, I won't say — because I always know and I know the people I'm working for so I've got a little leniency. But I would — and we're going overtime, I'm going oh God. I'm starting to panic. And then I get in my car and I've got to speed and I get over there, and usually make it just fine. But I remember showing up last minute, which really doesn't happen to me. And there was a trombone player named Lloyd Ulyate. And this was his standard line. He's passed away. And he was one of the old guard from L.A. here. I don't know if you know who that is, but he was one of the top studio trombone players here for many, many years. And he played on the Oscars. As a matter of fact I did play a lot at the end of his career with him. And he looked back at me and he knew, because he had turned down the date that I took. So he wouldn't have that panic that I had to go — "Young man," he goes, "you've gambled and you have lost." And I just — so I try not to do that. But there are times I go man I hate to turn this down. This is a lot of money. And I don't want to get out of this one to do this one. But a lot of times I'll call the contractor and go, "What are the odds of going overtime on this?" They go, "Oh we're going to be done early, don't worry about it, take the other date."

MR: Okay.

WB: But I'll call and ask. And if they say I can't guarantee it then I have to decide whether I'm going to roll the dice or not.

MR: So when you get to a date and you get there early, is the music on the stand, and what is the first thing that you look for?

WB: The music sometimes is on the stand at that point but maybe not, maybe they're just passing it out. Warren Luening used to say — he never looked at the music. And he'd go, "Oh don't look at it, it's going to scare you." You know, and so he'd just leave the book closed and we'd open it up — and that's kind of what I usually do anyway. You know I look ahead a little bit sometimes, depending on who the writer is, you know, because I know this person has a tendency to write a little more difficult than some of the other

composers so I might just thumb through, what have we got here. Oh let me take a look at this real quick. You know. So I'll just finger through it or maybe put my mute in and play a hard lick or something. But most of the stuff is kind of another day in the office for the most part. You come in and just read it down and it's not so difficult that it can't be read down. But there are things that can be very, very challenging. So I glance at the music a little bit and then I just carry on with my warm-up.

MR: Okay. When I was in music school there was a group of us that were so intent on — we used the term "making it." We wanted to make it in the music business. And I'm not even sure we knew what it meant but I'm curious if you had that same feeling when you were young, and did you have an idea of what it meant to be successful or to make it?

WB: I did, and on the other side of the coin I really didn't. But the first time somebody paid me to play the trumpet I got into, when I got into high school I came into the high school jazz band from junior high, and the band director at the high school — and the band director of the junior high school was my first trumpet teacher. He was a very good player and I studied with him through high school. And he told the high school band director, "Hey I've got your lead trumpet player coming," you know, "this kid can play." And I had a lot of high chops. I've had range since I was a little kid, I had kind of natural chops. My range is the same now as it was when I was in the eighth grade, so hopefully I'm a better player but as far as range it's the same. So I came up into the high school and everybody had to move over. I came in as a ninth grader and the seniors — I played first trumpet as a freshman. And I got into this band, this top 40 band, with some of the seniors from the high school that played weddings and played local gigs. And they played top 40 music of the day. And we played at the Lynwood Bowling Alley I remember, Lynwood Bowl it was called, where I grew up, north of Long Beach. And we played a five hour gig in the lounge, and it was $20. And they handed me a twenty dollar bill at the end of the thing and I went, damn I just made $20 playing the trumpet. You know, a ninth grader making twenty bucks in 1972. It was like twenty bucks. And I go, man, doing what I love the most? So then I got it, we played a few gigs here and there, and then I got into this other band, when I was 15 I remember, because I was a sophomore, I was playing in another community big band and we were talking about how we get work, and the bass trombone player in this band happened to play in another top 40 band from East L.A. called City. And the trumpet player left the band or they fired the trumpet player or something, and I'd been playing in this big band with him. He goes, "Hey man, you want to play in this band, we work almost every weekend. Would you be interested." And I was like, "Well yeah, of course" you know. And my mom drove me to my first gig because I couldn't drive. I was 15. And they were all twenties, some of them, they were older than me. The singer was 30 I think at the time. So and this band made like 50 to 75

bucks and we'd play weddings on the weekends. So now all of a sudden I'm doing a couple of gigs and making 150 bucks on the weekends in the 70s. And I was like, man, I've made it, man. I never flipped burgers, or I never did any of that. Now I did do some other day jobs. I worked as a machinist because my father was a machinist. So the day jobs I took were those things. Then as I started playing I kind of made some money, you know, through high school, and I got to where I could drive eventually and of course could drive myself to the gigs. But then I thought well this is how it goes, and I've made it. Then when high school ended and some of these bands stopped working and I decided to go off to college and I'm going I'm not making any money, I'm not really practicing, I'm not really taking the trumpet very seriously. So I took a day job at McDonnell Douglas Aircraft, which is Boeing now, but, in Long Beach, because I needed a job. And I dropped out of school and I took this day job. And I barely played. I played on the weekends every once in a while one of these bands would have a gig and I would play, but it was kind of a rude awakening because nobody really groomed me for what you need to do to actually make a living playing music. You know you're not just going to play in a wedding band and make a living. You know what I mean? That's not going to happen. There's a variety of things you have to do, no matter where you live, and Los Angeles is an entertainment town here you know so it's one of the few places you can make a living as just a musician, you know if you're fortunate enough to be with the right crowd. So you know I would do several different things. You know it took me a long time, as I said how I got in the business, but it took many years, you know, for me to get into it. I ended up quitting the day job. I did get a chance to go on the road with this guy Buddy Miles.

MR: Oh, Buddy Miles, yeah.

WB: So I worked at the day job for one year, then I got a call to go on the road, so I took that. I said I want to go on the road. I was living with my parents at the time.

MR: You got to play [scats].

WB: A one hit wonder. Yeah. Exactly. It was actually a really cool band, and it's kind of a pivotal point in my career because you know we all kind of looked back, well how did our careers start. And the players I met on that band, two players in particular, one was named Brandon Fields, who is one of the best saxophone players you will ever hear; and then a guy named Jeff Jorgensen, who is also the other great saxophone player you'll ever hear, who is more unknown. But I'd never heard, I'd never played with any musicians at that point that played at this level. Like these sax players, I said oh my God, I mean just like it was a learning experience for me. And we got to be friends and it made me a better musician playing with them because we would talk about how we were phrasing and they'd go, "No, do that like this." They'd tell me how to play. You know you don't tell

the trumpet player how to play, but they told me how to play. And I learned a lot from them, and some of my best gigs after that came from knowing those players. Because we got to be friends. And so that exposed me to even greater musicians that they were playing with you know. And so I got to hear all these different players and I grew as a player from that.

MR: Mm hum. Was that music that you were playing with that group something that you guys learned by ear? Or were there charts?

WB: Well it's funny you should say that because when we were rehearsing, we were rehearsing to go into the recording studio then go on the road, so there was a record attached to this Buddy Miles thing. When we went into the studio, and this guy named Richard Griffin — Richard Griffith, and his, they called him "Cush." And he was this really cool guy man and he was quite a bit older than me, and he was the second trumpet player. He used to play with Parliament Funkadelic and he's on some of the recordings even, you'll see the name Richard "Cush" Griffith. And he was, unfortunately he had some really horrible drug problems and when we were on the road he was hocking his horns and stuff. And he ended up, he lived in Kentucky and he ended up dying. He had diabetes and he'd gone blind and he passed away. But — where was I going with this, I'm sorry.

MR: We were talking about charts or playing by ear.

WB: Oh yeah. So he did, we had twelve tunes we were going to record. And he'd done charts for six horns. There was two trumpets, a bone, and three saxes. So we were rehearsing them in the studio and they were great. Like they were fun man, and they were voiced great, this guy could write really nice. And then Buddy Miles would show up at the studio, three hours late, and he'd go, "Hey let me hear what you got for this tune." And we would play it and he goes, "well that's cool but I kind of hear this." And then he would fire up the B3 and he'd start singing licks to us. And those licks were the show. We ended up not playing one note of the music this guy wrote. And the stuff Buddy sang was nowhere near as good, you know it was very generic, but that's how we learned the show. And so there was no music. We had memorized it. And you know I jotted things down on music paper so I wouldn't forget. You know, but so yeah, I used to play, toured with Bobby Womack as well. And Bobby didn't like having any charts. If he'd see me writing the music down he'd go, "No, man, you don't need no charts, man, it's right here. The charts are right here." And you know what? There's something to that. He goes, "Man, how are you going to play music if you're looking at the music?" It's more of a street thing you know. And so but he was kind of right man. Because when you take that element out of the way of reading something, and you know it, that — there's an obstruction that's out of the way between you and the music. And so I could just

concentrate on playing the show and it was great. And thinking on my feet if something changes. What if he goes to the bridge four bars early like he would on a regular basis. I'm not buried in a chart and in the wrong place. I'm going, he's going to the bridge, you know.

MR: I totally agree. And I've been in horn bands like that where people never got rid of the music and you don't learn your place in it, you don't learn like my note is the fifth of this chord, you just never really learn that unless you start using the ears.

WB: Yeah. If you take your eyes out of the equation, the other senses take over you know. So I feel the same way about, on the technical side. Because I'm a big promoter of tuners, using digital tuners, for a learning tool. And I have some that I clip on my bell because like sometimes I'm in a situation where I can't hear the bass and I want to have some reference of where I'm at. But if you use a tuner and you just stare at it all the time, you stop listening with your ears and you start listening with your eyes. You know? And so what I suggest with tuners for players, I said, "Tuners are great and I think they're as valuable as a metronome. But you wouldn't bring a metronome to a gig and then say 'hey they're rushing or dragging,' you'll be flexible of course." You know. But with the tuner what I'll do is I shut my eyes and I hit a note, and I bend the note up and down and I try to find the bull's eye of the note, where it's resonant. And then I'll open my eyes and I'll look at the tuner. And I'll go okay, there, that's right in tune there, and that's where the sound is most resonant. Funny how that works you know.

MR: Yeah.

WB: Or, it can also tell you where you need to put your slide, your tuning slide. Because if you shut your eyes and you're in the most resonant place and you open your eyes and it's reading sharp, well then you're not playing down the middle of the instrument — you're playing down the middle of the instrument but the instrument is too short. You have to lengthen it a little bit.

MR: I see.

WB: Because to really be in tune now you're blipping the notes. And so that creates another — so that's a little something I've learned from using those. And I know players that try to stare at them, a couple of French horn players I'd worked with in the pit are really self-conscious about their pitch because in the pit it sounds like hell and it's hard to hear and it makes you very not confident about where you're putting your note. Your French horn might be behind us and you can't hear us. So he would use a tuner all the time, this guy. And I'd hear, like we'd hit a chord and it'd be perfectly in tune, and then I'd hear him bending his note down because it says he's sharp. But he maybe has the minor third or something you know. And he needs to be bringing it up. You know. So stuff like that can

happen. I think the tuner is a really important tool in our practice, though, if used in the right way anyway.

MR: Did the fact that you started on the French horn have anything to do with that you could seem to play naturally high when you got to the trumpet?

WB: It most definitely did. Because of the shape of that French horn mouthpiece and the depth of it. And when I went to a mouthpiece that had a cup way up here, and I just tried to play it the same way, I mean I was just learning how to play, but I started squeaking these funny sounds. You know I was squeaking these high notes and I couldn't make a note in the lower register. So it got to where that became something I could do. And that's probably why I still play, because I got a lot of attention for doing this. You know when I discovered I could hit a double high C man, and nobody else could, you know, talking about egos as we did earlier, well when your twelve years old and you can hit a double high C your ego inflates pretty fast, you know, especially when there's nothing else ever I was very good at. You know I sucked at sports and you know I didn't have any musical ability. And none of these older trumpet players could do it, and I was like wow, I'm all that. That's how I felt about myself when I was a kid you know. I put a double high C, you know, I heard you know Maynard Ferguson playing high notes on the end of a tune so I just played a high note on the end of everything we ever played. I played a double high C. It didn't matter what the chord was or anything, I just played double high C, because my friends are going "All right!" and they'd high five me.

MR: Oh that's very cute. I can just picture being, you know, like a lot of people I've done my share of adjudications at high school festivals. I can just picture that. Like gee that was a high note but are you sure you want him playing that?

WB: Yeah that note doesn't really work in that chord. But I've talked to Bobby Shew about this, because I just took a lesson with Bobby a few weeks ago. Because as I had gone through my cancer treatments and stuff, I'm still recovering in many ways, strength wise. And so I took a lesson with Bobby. And we're good friends. And he adjudicated me when I was a kid. And so we joke about that a lot.

MR: Oh no kidding.

WB: "Man," he goes, "I remember you looked like you were going to explode" you know, "but man, you had some chops you know." He goes, "I heard this kid playing a high G in the eighth grade," and so we joke about that, you know. And Pat Williams is another one, the composer, you know. I worked for him quite a bit in the last fifteen years of his life. And I talked to him, because he was a guest artist with this youth band that I was in. Yeah, he was a guest composer, and he was also an adjudicator at the Hollywood Bowl Battle of the Bands when I was a kid. So I reminded him of that. I go, "You actually judged me and you said something really nice about me in the thing" so it really came

full circle. It was kind of neat to be working for him actually, much, much later in life you know. Unfortunately we lost him a couple of years ago.

MR: Yeah, I loved his writing.

WB: I just did a — I'll share a little something with you when we — after we hang up. I did a tribute recording to him that I just mixed and mastered. I did "The Bob Newhart Theme." And I had Tom Kubis do a really nice arrangement of it, and I've got strings on it and everything. And I'll send it to you. It's going to get released on January 1 as a matter of fact, just as a little single. And I did it for Pat's wife, so I'm going to send it to her.

MR: Okay. I got to play that theme, he came to Utica, New York.

WB: Oh Bob Newhart did?

MR: I was in the group so I got to play that theme.

WB: Yeah I did an HBO special for Bob Newhart, you know, thirty years ago probably. And I've always loved that — that's a theme that's always stuck with me, and that [scats] Buddy Childers, you know, played that beautiful soaring trumpet. And from the time I was a kid I always liked that. That melody has been in my head, and so when I started working for Pat, you know, I was like so excited to be playing for him and so I decided to record that and just get it off my chest after all these years you know.

MR: Speaking of being a kid, I recall, I was a reader of liner notes on LPs, right?

WB: Me too, yeah.

MR: So you see, okay here's Frank Wess with Basie and then you see Frank Wess over here. And here's Snooky Young here, and then he shows up — and I used to just love watching the musical chairs. And I'm wondering if you were like that, and did you latch on to some of those lead trumpet players?

WB: Most definitely. And more in the pop world, because I would look at all these records and I kept seeing these three names: Jerry Hey, Chuck Findley, and Gary Grant. I mean on every record that I liked, you know, whether it was an Earth, Wind and Fire record or whatever, I would just keep seeing these names. I go man who are these? They're on everything. And everything they do sounds great too you know. And so when one of them wasn't there, you know as a kid I'd look at those things and go, "Wow, Chuck Findley's not on this one. And Steve Madaio, who's that? Why is Chuck Findley not there?" And I did the same with big band records because I'd look at the band and it'd be these set bands then all of a sudden it'd be somebody different in the personnel. "Well what happened to" such-and-such? Did they die? Did they get fired? You know, and I saw things like that as a kid. But I love looking at liner notes and reading who was on what. And then you'd start seeing the names crossing over, like maybe some of the big band things. And then you'd see Snooky Young's name on a pop record in the horn

section. You'd go, "Wow, isn't he with Count Basie? How could he be doing these two gigs at once?"

MR: Yes that's so interesting. And it used to bother me when you'd be listening to some of these records where they wouldn't list anybody. And God darn, I want to know who that is.

WB: Yeah, fortunately, well a lot of these things the people are documenting them now you know, even the Frank Sinatra records they didn't have the personnel on them. We know who it is, from history you know, but they're not listed on there. And my wife and I were watching, we watched the movie "Soul" last night, the new Pixar movie.

MR: As did we.

WB: Really cute. And I worked on that movie, so I did a lot of the underscore. And I played the opening scene where it sounds like a middle school band. I'm playing first trumpet on that.

MR: Oh come on now.

WB: I'll send you the clip of that too, so you can hear the other side of the coin. And they also used the elementary school band, you did hear them a little bit in the movie, which was really great I thought. They used them.

MR: Okay. But are you telling me that that opening thing was all professional musicians?

WB: Yeah. I have videos of me in the studio with my headphone on my stand, playing it. That was all professional musicians.

MR: How do you do that? How do you make yourself sound like a sixth grader?

WB: Some of the guys played the horns upside down like Clark Terry and so it makes the fingering real sloppy. We pulled our slides in and out and then tried to just play to where the pitch would be. The saxophone players were doing the same, like squeaking on purpose. You know there's a point where we went too far, they go, "That's too bad, we can't recognize the melody." All right, we've done it, we played it so bad. And so then we did several versions and we had to reel it in. And then you play out of time. We don't talk about it too much, we kind of know what to do. You know you miss the key signature, you know, especially on inner parts so there's a good wrong note in there. The drums are crashing and banging out of time. The bass is completely out of tune of course and the last chord goes [distorted scat]. So we do, it's actually very funny to do, and I've had to do that several times throughout my career, play — be in a high school pep band or something you know. So they did use some kids in that movie though, but my point being was Andy Martin, great trombone jazz player from here, one of the kids in the band that's really good actually is this gal that plays trombone and she's a main character in the show. And this trombone soloing comes up from her like three or four times in the movie. And he didn't get screen credit.

MR: Even the musicians that did, you had to like stay and watch the credits for like five minutes until they showed up and I just don't understand that.

WB: I mean they showed Tia Fuller, who played the saxophone stuff on there. And they showed the New York band that did that one scene. But we played on the whole score, you know, all the horn stuff and the action of entered cues and a couple of high notes. Well I played on all that, and I played on way more than they did, so you'd think — but that being, I don't really care. But that being said, Andy Martin's name should have been on there, trombone solo Andy Martin, because everybody was asking about it.

MR: Well now I know at least.

WB: So what we're doing now in our new contract with the A F of M, in the film agreement, is they're going to be putting us in, it's part of the new deal, movies over a certain budget have to include the musicians now.

MR: I was wondering how you — I mean are there certain things that, from what I know, that you get residuals for and things, but others you don't. Would you know if you were supposed to be getting residuals and you didn't?

WB: You mean if somebody was being dishonest?

MR: Yeah, if you were supposed to be getting payments for something, are you organized enough that you know?

WB: There's no way I could keep track of that. So what they do, I mean it depends. Like for a commercial let's say, a television commercial. They get 13 weeks before they have to give you another payment. And then you get 75% of your original payment. So if you do a commercial that runs for 13 weeks and that's it, you don't get any more money. If it runs another cycle you'll get another payment, and then another payment. Now depending on how many spots they made out of it, like there's been a couple of commercials that have been very lucrative for me. I still get paid from a Jack in the Box commercial I did in 1994. It's not much, I still get a couple of checks you know. It's like unbelievable, it's still running somewhere. But I did a Safeway commercial, Safeway supermarkets, I don't know if they have those where you're at. But, and we had to play "The Way You Look Tonight" but more like "Cute" with a Harmon muted trumpet, bass and drums. So it went [scats] you know it was like "Cute." And that was for the jingle. And I didn't think too much about it. We did that thing, and then in my mailbox about 13 weeks later my mailbox was stuffed with rubber bands around them, of these checks. And I didn't know what it was and I'm like oh my God. And I'm opening these checks up, and they're for this Safeway commercial. Now usually you would just see a couple of checks, right? Because they had two spots or something. Well what they decided to do was buy us out for the year of all the regions. So instead of cutting just one check though, the system doesn't work that way, so they cut individual checks. So I got all these checks

with like 75% of it, so I got all these checks for $172 and change, 50 of them. And then the next day, another 50 showed up. And I'm going we can just keep this going, I don't mind signing these things. I was getting pissed off, I had to go buy a stamp. Like can't they just put this in one check? It's a first world problem you know. So but those kind of things are few and far in between for a commercial jingle. And I'll tell you one more funny story about a commercial that I did, for Safeway as well. And they used to have these jingle houses here, and they still exist, but we would go do demos for them. So you'd go to this place and there's be ten composers there and they're all trying to get this jingle, whatever it is, a Coke commercial or whatever. So they might need trumpet and you'd go from room to room and you would play for these different things. And if one of them got it you'd get called back to do the final, and you'd get paid for the demo, whatever that would be you know. And I'm trying to remember the little lick I played for the Safeway thing though — God I'm forgetting it now. But anyway this little riff went like [scats] I'm singing actually a radio ID now, but it was something like that. And there was no music. And he goes can you just play a little melody kind of thing, can you come up with something? Oh yeah. How about this? And so I played this thing and he goes, "Oh that's perfect." And it was a thing that didn't resolve, it went like [scats] and it never went [scats]. And he goes that's perfect. Well that particular commercial was a buyout. And they gave me $500 to do this. "Hey would you do this non-union" which I usually don't do. This was many many years ago though. $500. So I made $500 bucks. Man, all right. It took me 20 minutes. I'll take that you know. Well that commercial became their national spot and ran for ten years. And not only did they use my melody, so I'm actually the composer, which I never got paid for, which would have equaled lots of dollars. They had different instrumentalists coming in and playing it over the years, probably just to buy-out with them too. Like a saxophone player playing my lick, an opera singer singing my lick. And so every time I'd hear it I just went [gags] you know. What did we learn? I could have probably retired off the money I would have made on this if I was the composer, if I was credited as the composer. It's funny that I can't think of how it went anymore.

MR: I think it's a mental block. You don't want to torture yourself anymore.

WB: So if somebody wants to just pay you for a buy out I mean I wouldn't do that now anyway, just 'cause I don't need to do that anymore. But at the time man, $500 is a lot of money and yeah, I'll do that. And now when it comes to a commercial jingle if you're going to buy me out it's going to cost you a lot more than that, especially if I'm going to make up the part you know, and I'm going to risk getting in trouble with the union. So I don't really do that. It's got to be on a union contract and be right.

MR: Was it, is it possible to not be all in with studio work? Like let's say you got to a point, you wanted to cut back a little bit so I'm not going to accept any Saturday dates or whatever. Is it possible to do that or do you find that if you're trying to step out a little bit that you're going to end up stepping out completely?

WB: If you did it a lot — but I think that most of the people I work for, because I always look at like there's contractors and there's composers and there's orchestrators. And the orchestrators and the composers are actually more powerful than the contractors. Because many of them will have their list of musicians that they like, or, depending on the kind of music it is who they want there. So I have composers that I work for that are always going to have me on their list. It's going to say Wayne Bergeron first trumpet, or in the section or whatever you know. I want such and such. I want John Lewis for first trumpet on the classical stuff and I want Wayne for the commercial stuff you know. It might be that. So that contractor has to call me, because I'm on the list. They have to, even if they don't want to they technically have to call me. So if you turn down a session, you just say oh I can't make that I'm already committed, I usually don't say I don't want to do those days, I'll just say oh I'm not available. And that way you remain on the list. It would take a lot to bump you off of a list.

MR: I see.

WB: You'd have to be saying no to the same contractor over and over and over you know, for them to bump you off their list I would think. You know. Or you have to really piss them off, like I mentioned earlier you know.

MR: Would someone like Henry Mancini say I'm not doing this recording unless I get these four particular players? Would they hold the thing up until a time where all those people are available?

WB: If he wanted that, of course they would. I mean most of the time they've got alternates. They go, oh man, Plas Johnson can't do this one, you know, but we have to do this today. Who's your next choice? Who do you like? You know such-and-such sounds like Plas you know, or we'll get Pete Christlieb or whatever you know. So they probably do that. But there's been times even in my thing where they've said — where I couldn't be there and they're writing for me and they've rescheduled the thing. That's a kind of a good feeling to have.

MR: Indeed.

WB: It's a powerful — in the music business it's a very powerful thing to be able to say no, when you're in a position to say no in any business it makes you more valuable, because you don't need that. If you don't need it, you know what I mean, if you don't need that work or you don't have to do this, and you say no, it's a good — there's something that feels good about that, especially in the music business because we're so used to saying

yes to everything and being a slave to the music business. And like you said earlier, trying to make every session and make every call. And there's a little bit of greed involved with that but there's also a little bit of need involved with that because people need to make money. And that extra money can make or break some people. So you know, yeah.

MR: Did you ever have a circumstance, like an orchestra or large group, where you had a very prominent part and you hit a clam and they had to do it again?

WB: Oh that's probably happened a time or two in my career. You could ask any musician on the planet and if they said no they would be lying to you.

MR: Okay.

WB: Especially if it's the trumpet, because hear that right now? I just heard Wynton Marsalis clam a note right now, and he doesn't make mistakes. So of course, and usually it's kind of funny, especially if it's a big clam you know, and you've played it right five times in a row you know, and then it might make people laugh. Like, "Oh that's the keeper, all right, great." So of course the goal is not to make any mistakes, but I come from the mindset of, I try not to play too carefully. I try to play as musically as effective to whatever I'm playing as it needs to be. And that means taking a risk of not being careful. Because you can always hear somebody when they're being careful playing. It loses some heart. Especially if you're playing a ballad or you're playing something slower or a classical kind of melody where you have to go [scats] or something like that, and you're being real careful to make the slurs real clean. It's going to come off [scats] it's going to come off like a military instead of having some — but if you just play it and trust your skills that you can make those slurs nice and just play from here. Maybe you'll clam a note but you'll get the take, the take you get will be the one. And I guess the idea is to get your skills to the level where you don't have to think about the technical part of it so much and just play music. We all get a little bit nervous about that especially when we're blowing in the end of a brass instrument when the target is that big. There's a lot that can go wrong here if you're not in the bull's eye. If you're playing the trombone or the tuba there's a little more forgiveness. A little bit. I mean they have their issues as well but the trumpet or the French horn, there's very little room for error so that's why we tend to clam more notes.

MR: I'm glad you mentioned Bobby Shew because he told me a little thing that he learned from someone else, that helped him keep sane in the studio and that was, "You play this and I'll play that."

WB: Yeah.

MR: Passing parts around?

WB: We do that. Not a lot. I mean on a film call it's a little bit unethical because the money is very different from first trumpet to second trumpet.

MR: I see.

WB: So on a film call first trumpet pays 200 — pays 100% extra scale, so it's double scale. Plus if you play another instrument then it's another 50% on top of that double, so if you play the flugelhorn or the piccolo trumpet then it goes up to 250%. So if you're having somebody play all the hard stuff, you know, and we have a kind of an unwritten rule here in Los Angeles that trumpet players get what we call the guaranteed double. So on a film call everybody gets 150% in the trumpet section, whether we play a double or not. But if we do play one we don't get any more. We get that. It's a standard — it's kind of an unwritten rule and it was established by some of the older guard musicians that worked here many years before I did. And the idea of that was why is somebody playing such an exposed instrument making the same money as the last stand violinist? Where if that third trumpet player clams they're fired. But if you've got 30 violins over there and the last stand violinist is not playing very well, nobody knows. So nothing, you know, which most of the violinists here can play but that's the reasoning behind that. It's not really greed and it's not ego, it's kind of like you're getting combat pay.

MR: Yeah.

WB: So if you're making 50% less right out of the chute, and somebody's handing you all of the hardest stuff, which has happened to me throughout my career by the way. I've played some hard stuff for some other players. But you know, it's okay because if you're doing one or two things, but let's just get the job done. It takes some pressure off. Because I've had to pass — I've taken parts too, "Hey would you mind playing this?" some very exposed classical thing. Now I've been banging my head against the wall all day playing all this other hard stuff so I've earned my money at least. But we kind of do that for each other, 'cause the object is to get the music recorded as best as possible. So if you've got your A team pinch hitter coming in, hey man, this is what this person does in a clutch, you let them play it. Or I could sit there and rear my ego and go oh I can do this, I've got this. And I might be able to play it okay, but can I play it as well as that person? Probably not.

MR: Okay. This is great stuff.

WB: You know? So you have to kind of check your ego at the door when you walk in.

MR: I have a brief anecdote. I've been doing a weekly Zoom with the fellows I graduated with from SUNY Fredonia, we were all in the jazz band. And most of them are trumpet players who chime in. And when I told them that I was going to be interviewing you, they all went, "Oh, oh, Wayne, oh. He's at least as good as Maynard and when he gets up

high his sound gets even wider." So I want to tell you you have a strong fan base in my demographic.

WB: Oh man, that's very sweet. I would completely disagree with him as a comparison with Maynard, even though there's not a note I play that doesn't have Maynard Ferguson in it you know, a little bit. I really don't like being compared to him because he was such, the greatest brass — what did Adolph Herseth call him — the greatest brass specimen of all time. You know, because he could just do things besides his high notes. He could just do things that were easy to him. And obviously he was very inspiring to a lot of us trumpet player you know. But you know I couldn't do one tenth of the things Maynard could do you know, in his prime especially. But I appreciate the compliment of course and it's very flattering. But what I do and what Maynard did are very very different things you know. I'm a journeyman working trumpet player that sits and plays in the trumpet section and plays in the studios and has to play kind of classically at times. And Maynard was a rock star of the trumpet you know. He did what he did, you know, and you probably wouldn't want to hear him on Brahms necessarily. But he was a beautiful musician and he was a dear friend of mine. So, he passed. I played on his final CD as a guest you know. He got me in and he did a tune on one of my CDs with me, six months before he passed away. And it saddened me. He seemed so invincible to me.

MR: Yes.

WB: So when he died it was like oh my God, man, how can Maynard be gone? So playing with him, it's funny, I just pulled out my Maynard Ferguson tour jacket from 1986. I pulled it out today because I'm so much thinner now that it fits me again. I used to be a 39 long, as far as my sports coat. And then I went up to a 48 long at my heaviest. I don't know what I am now but I'm probably a 44 now. But that jacket was always big on me back then. And I put it on today and it fits, and I was like oh wow. That's funny that you brought up Maynard because I put that jacket on. I want to preserve it. I think I'm going to put it in a shadow box or something. It'll be a collector's item for somebody someday.

MR: Wasn't a big part of his success as a trumpet player having something to do with his breathing?

WB: Yeah. I mean he talked about, you know, the yoga breath and things he learned in India, and which Bobby Shew teaches as well. And Bobby Shew kind of learned these things from him. So I would say yes. But Maynard was doing that long before he learned how to do that. I mean Maynard was playing unbelievably efficient way before he learned about Eastern philosophy and different kinds of breathing. I mean I think it enhanced his playing later and made him even more efficient. And Bobby Shew, you know, teaches a thing called the wedge breath, which is all based on these things that Maynard did, which I do. Like I said I just took another lesson with Bobby recently. I mean I think, just let it

be known, I think Bobby Shew is the greatest brass educator in a hundred years. Because, you know, us trumpet players and brass players, we kind of have our heads stuck in the sand of tradition and that's Bobby's line. You've got your head stuck in the sand of tradition. When you're looking at these books and concepts from over a hundred years ago, you know, things around the turn of the century, you know of the 1900s, of how we played the trumpet or the cornet at the time. And we're still trying to apply those to modern day musicians. Now are those things valid? Of course. There's a lot of great information in the foundation of where those players come from. But we've also learned a few things over the years. I mean, you know, we know that the computer is going to do better math than an abacus you know. So we kind of need to move on and kind of learn from technology a little bit. You know we've made some better trumpets, even though a lot of people say, "Oh the old horns are better." They're not better. There was a lot of old horns that were great. A lot of them sucked because they were so inconsistent. We've learned a lot of stuff. You know fine tooling machining is going to be better than some wiggly lathe they used in the 30s, you know, to cut a piece of metal. Let's face it. You know so they can say that all they want. And the metal was better — I don't buy any of it. But, so we've learned a few things. And we've learned a few things about efficiency and how to play the trumpet more efficiently, and maybe the mouthpiece being able to help a little bit and where there's that school of thought that, oh you just play the mouthpiece that came with the horn and you work hard. Or you play a 7C and you just work hard and you do everything on that mouthpiece. Well you can do that and your career is probably going to be over by the time you're 55 years old because you've been working so hard that your body shuts down. And a lot of players from yesteryear, you know, from the 40s that played bigger mouthpieces than kind of we do now, all their careers were — very few of them were playing into their 80s of any of them. Whereas now we have Doc Severinsen at 93 years old who can still hit a high G. And we have Bobby Shew who is going to be 80 years old very soon, and he can still play a double high C better than most 30 year olds. So we've learned a few things about how to be more efficient and how to use the right equipment for the job. And Bobby is a big proponent of that, of getting players to be smart about their equipment. And I learned that way too late in life. But here I'm going to be 63 years old in a few weeks and I'm stronger. And even recovering from cancer and losing 50 pounds and I'm still coming back, I'm stronger right now at this moment than I was when I was 30, as a player. I could bury a 30-year-old Wayne Bergeron. I could bury him, endurance-wise and everything. So I did something right along the way and I think grasping something that Bobby Shew said along the way is why I can do that. And a few other people too that I've learned from of course.

MR: Speaking of a 30-year-old Wayne, I'm going to go back a little farther than that and create a fictional scenario. If you were 21 or 2, and you got a call to sub on lead trumpet with the Count Basie orchestra on a Sunday, and then you got, unbelievably, a second call to sub on lead trumpet on the Buddy Rich orchestra the next day, what would be the difference in those gigs as far as playing lead trumpet?

WB: Well I would have picked Count Basie's band and said no to Buddy first of all. Because it's funny you should mention Count Basie because of any name band that I would have ever wanted to really play — I mean I would have liked to play with any of them. But to play with Count Basie, in that band, because that's the music that moves my soul. You know I do a lot of other things to make a living but my wife will tell you when I'm playing, you know, a Billy Byers' chart, or a Frank Foster chart, or a Sammy Nestico chart, I just go Pffw — here we go. This is my shit. You know? And I just can sink my teeth into it and they're playable. They're difficult but there's no pyrotechnics involved it's just all about feel and about where you put the time and going through high school my band director was all about Count Basie. So in the 70s, that's when Sammy Nestico was writing a lot. He'd written a lot for the Count Basie band in the late 60s. So all those charts that came, "Basie Straight Ahead" and all those things that we know and love, I grew up and started playing, my first chart I ever played in junior high was a watered down version of "The Queen Bee." The first big band chart I ever played. Sammy Nestico chart. So I've always just kind of loved that music and it's embedded in me, and so that kind of music is what moves my soul. And I loved Buddy Rich too, and Buddy Rich had a swinging band. But there was something about that other thing. And to answer your question, at 21 I would have had to say no and I think I was even smart enough to realize I wasn't ready musically.

MR: Okay.

WB: I wasn't ready, at 21 years old I wasn't ready. I could have been if I would have paid more attention through high school. And it's almost a problem that I had some natural ability because I let that carry me through as far as it could, and I wasn't working on my craft, and I wasn't practicing enough, and I wasn't listening enough. I could do the things I had to do and I could play a Basie chart pretty good because I kind of knew it. But you know to really, I didn't have the — at 21 I didn't have the maturity of time or any of that I don't think to have sat with that band and done the lead chair justice. And Buddy's band would have probably just chewed me up and spit me out you know.

MR: Okay. Well is there a difference, if you're playing with the Tom Kubis band or Gordon Goodwin or formerly the Juggernaut, the drummer — I mean I've been told that the drummer and the lead trumpet player have to be in sync. And I don't have a question here

except that if you're just on this date for one gig how long does it take you to figure out where the drummer is at?

WB: Not very long at all. I just answered this question for somebody else the other day. They were asking me about what I — and I try to go to where — because to get the drummer to budge it's going to be more difficult. You know? So because here's the beat and here's the front half of the beat and here's the back half of the beat. This is all correct. Right? And so some drummers play, you know like when they're playing quarter notes they go [scats] so that middle note of the shuffle [scats] some drummers play it on the later part of the beat and they go [scats]. Some play it on the other side. They go [scats]. Like Art Blakey kind of does that a lot [scats] which I think swings really hard you know. And that has to move around depending on the tempo of course. And then some play right down the middle. They go [scats]. Right? You hear how those three things sound very different even singing them. Well when you're playing eighth notes, especially if the tempo is slow, you need to be aware of where the drummer's feel is. And if it's going to be later you can tug on the beat more. You don't want to drag. I don't like the term "lay back." I don't even — I think that word should be eliminated from education. Because laying back means displacing the time. Count Basie's band didn't drag. They laid back. They'd go [scats] when it was written [scats] right? They just changed the rhythm so they'd tug on this thing, and it was a thing that [scats] you know? And that was written [scats]. That's how that's written. So that's laying back to me, where they take the time and they put it in another alternative universe for a minute and then it corrects. So I think playing good time within the rules of the beat you can tug on the beat. You can go [scats]. Right? Whatever tune that is, basically blues or whatever tune that is. I'm tugging at the beat but I'm still in time. I'm not going [scats]. I'm not dragging you know. And so kids, when they say to lay back they start dragging. And even if you're playing a slow swing chart it has to have forward motion even if you're tugging at the beat, if that makes any senses. So I think that we do kids an injustice by telling them to lay back. No make them play in time. Good time swings really hard. And to quote Andy Martin, who is one of my best friends and also one of my very favorite trombone players on this planet, when somebody starts dragging, his line is "dragging isn't swinging." So anyway, that's what I look for. I just kind of find where the drummer is at and if the drummer plays here I'll play with them so we're lined up. Especially if I'm going to come into a situation. Frank Capp was really fun to play with because he had a hard swinging right hand, old school, which I like I think because I was just born thirty years too late probably. But Peter Erskine has that. I love playing with Peter Erskine. Whenever I play with him, we play in Dave Slonaker's band and we played on several recordings together. And I just know where he's going to put everything. We're going to go [scats] I know where that note's going to

be. On Pat Williams' record man, we have a bunch of stuff like that. And we always look over and smile. I always look at him and go yeah. We have a little connection you know.

MR: That's an awesome feeling, yeah.

WB: It's kind of a neat thing. Now sometimes I'm fighting a drummer a little bit — okay I'll play that here. Or maybe they may hear me doing that and they make adjustments. As the lead trumpet player I'm not in charge of the drummer's feel you know. I've got to kind of play with him or her too.

MR: Well you've said some wonderful things today. I'm going to wrap up with — I have two more questions and they may be — will I'll just ask. The year 2020 of course we have this pandemic going on but you also had a bout with cancer. And I wonder if it made you think about life differently?

WB: Most definitely man. I mean I've always taking life pretty seriously and tried to be a compassionate person in my life just in general towards other people. But now, I mean when you get something that threatens your existence happening to you, you know I never felt sorry for myself or anything, I mean at first I did. You know when I got that news it was two days after all my work went away from the pandemic mind you. So all my career went away. And then two days later I was diagnosed with cancer. So I was pretty much — if anybody deserved to be woe is me for just a minute, I mean I should have had a little license to go "woe is me." Poor Wayne. And I did do that for a minute. And I used to think, you know I used to say cancer man, why me? You know. And then I started thinking well why not me? It doesn't really, you don't get to pick. And fortunately for me I had a cancer that was very curable, as the doctors told me. They said, "Well the good news is if you're going to get cancer this is the cancer to get." I was like oh that's reassuring. You know. But they said but there's no worse treatment. So I had that to look forward to. And he said to me, "And mind you, untreated this will kill you," so in case I was considering not doing treatment you know. Because some people try to go alternative. Because he goes, "It will kill you." This is what you need to do. So I needed to do 35 radiations and 7 weeks of chemo. And so I did that and it sucked. I know it sounds like it was fun but putting that mask on I showed you every day and going in there and having the effects of radiation frying my neck and my skin getting burned and burned on the inside too. And you know they were frying this giant tumor that was here and getting very sick from the chemo. And there is a lot of stuff that just happens to you man, I could go on for two hours about the horrible things that happened. But you can kind of survive it. You know we've all been sick and you get to the point where you just kind of get numb to it every day. And I just felt fortunate that I had a very good chance of living. So I cry a lot easier than I used to, about things you know. I get teared up a lot easier than I used to. I mean I was always kind of a wimp anyway, you know I cried at Bambi. But

now when I see something on TV if I see a St. Jude's commercial come on, St. Jude's Hospital, man I just start bawling. And I think I'm a little more sensitive than I used to be. And I'm also a little more tolerant of things that would bother me a lot quicker. I try to go I don't know what that person's story is so I'm not going to judge them as quickly, even though they might be doing some really stupid shit. I'm not going to judge them right away. So it's changed me in that way a little bit. It's made me healthier. I'm definitely thinking about my health, like I said, I just came from Pilates, said Wayne Bergeron never. But I'm going to it man and I'm embracing my new weight and I'm trying to get strong so — when you lose weight as a trumpet player that mass helps you. You know if you're used to playing against it. And you lost that much weight all of a sudden and take a bunch of time off because of treatments and start coming back, I was weak. And so I'm trying to get my body strong. So I'm thinking about my health more now and I appreciate my wife more because she takes such incredible care of me through this. And I couldn't have, I'm really fortunate that I got cancer when I did, during that pandemic. Because there was no work. So I would have been worried about not working. You talked about residuals earlier, my movie residual check that comes in July every year which is kind of a big part of my income, they gave it to us two months earlier, they gave it to us on May 1 to help everybody out, they did the calculations and I started taking my musicians' pension on May 1 as well, just because I figured I was going to need the money. And then I was on disability. So it kind of helped, financially I'm okay. And I didn't have the worry of that. You know so it was a good time to get cancer if there is a good time. I couldn't have picked a better time to get sick you know, and it still is not a lot of work. We've gone back into the studios a little bit but I don't have a lot of pressure on me right now and that's a big factor man, because that would be rough, you know if I was thinking about every gig that I was missing. So I feel extremely fortunate and I count my lucky stars every day for a lot of things.

MR: Well I think I'm going to leave our talk on that upbeat note and I appreciate you spending your time with me today. And just a closing comment, your first solo CD was "You Call This a Living" and I think we can say yes.

WB: Gordon Goodwin gave me that title.

MR: Is this a living for you?

WB: Because he asked me how long I'd been playing for a living, I go "You Call this a Living?" and that's where that title came from, from another interview from many, many years ago.

MR: And who did the interview did you say?

WB: Gordon Goodwin. It was when he first started his band you know.

MR: Okay.

WB: And the other positive thing I just wanted to say, is I got to keep my hair. You know the chemo didn't take my hair. The radiation took it in the back but it grew back. Not that I care but you know I've always had good hair and I'm 62 with no gray hair you know, and so there's not a lot of people that get to say that, so I'm always proud of my hair. As a matter of fact it looks like I dye my hair and I do not dye it.

MR: All right. We have it on record now.

WB: Yeah. And the people go, "Is that a rug?" I go no, this is my hair. So you know I got to keep my hair too so that's a big plus. I was ready to shave my head to be honest with you, because I just figured I'd be losing my hair, which would be okay too, I'd just wear some hats, you know I'd embrace my baldness.

MR: Well congratulations on that and for your whole career, and this has been marvelous.

WB: Yeah, thank you, Monk, this is a great interview and I'm glad this wasn't — I like doing these things that are not so preconceived and we could just talk about some stuff and they just flow better I think.

MR: Me too.

WB: And everybody already knows what kind of mouthpiece I play. We don't need to get into any of that you know.

MR: Very good.

WB: Yeah, it's been very, very nice man, and thank you for including me in this. It's really appreciated. And hopefully our paths will cross in person at some point.

MR: I hope so too.

WB: Great, Monk.